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HEADING FOR DIV

By pulling his ministers out from the government, Sharif could ultimately end up playing into Musharraf's hands

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

When former premier Nawaz Sharif announced on May 12 that he was pulling his party's nine ministers out of the six-week-old coalition government, not many people were surprised. Many opposition politicians had predicted from the beginning that the alliance between former bitter rivals Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) and Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League—Nawaz (PML-N) as an unnatural one. Pandits had weighed in on the different "cultures" and "ideological moorings" of the two parties, one a liberal-left national party that drew its strength from rural Sindh, the other a centre-right force banking heavily on urban Punjab. Geo Television's popular current affairs host, journalist Kamran Khan, led his nightly programme on May 12 with the cheeky heading "The Coalition Breaks Up—It Was Bound to Happen, And It Did."

Cracks had been apparent in the coalition right since the February 18 elections over the issue of the restoration of superior court judges sacked by General Musharraf on November 3 last year. Sharif, who had included the popular demand in PML-N's election manifesto, predicated his party's participation in the Government on PPP's promise that the new government would reinstall the old judges. After the Bhurban Accord, in which Sharif and PPP leader Asif Ali Zardari commit to restore the judges within 30 days, the legal fraternity, civil society groups and the media had begun a highly publicised countdown. Despite denials from PPP, it had become increasingly clear over time that Zardari—who had endured more than 11 years in jail on unproven charges—had serious

